

SIDDHĀNTABINDU

OF
SRIMAT MADHUSŪDANA SARASVATI

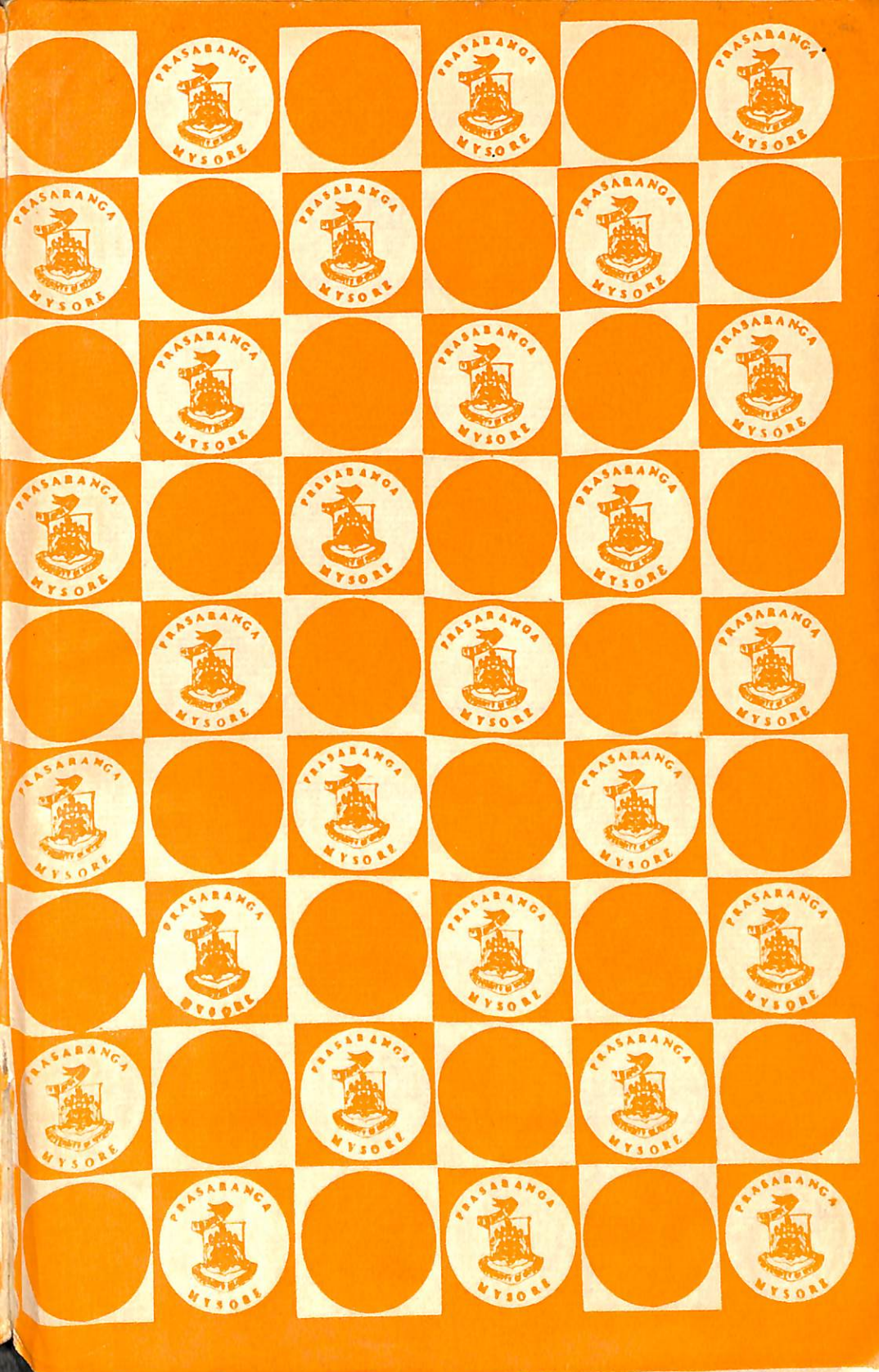
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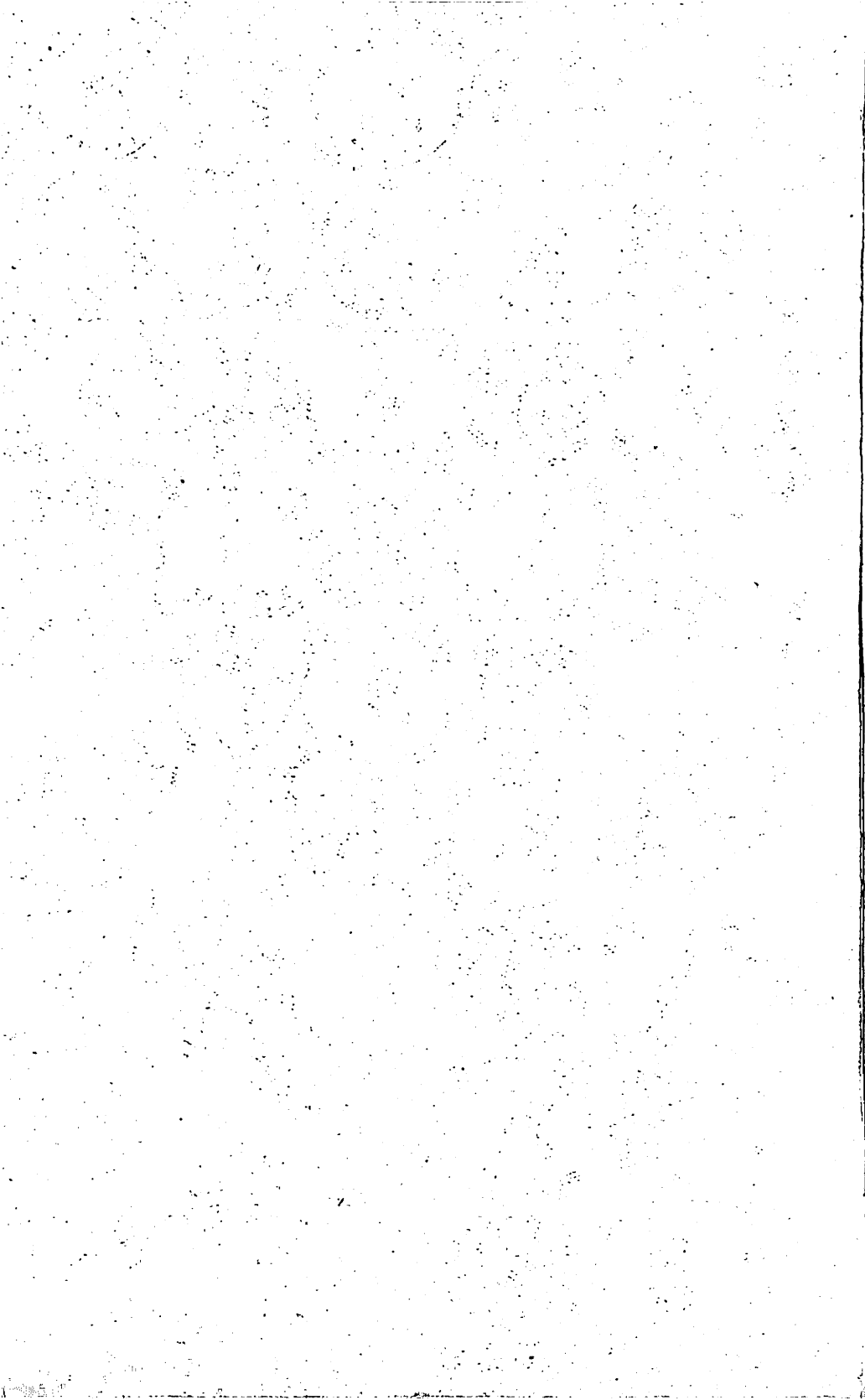


1981

Srimān Madhusudana Sarasvati (c. 1520-1627), the author of the text is one of the classical writers on Advaita Vedanta. His best known work Advaitasiddhi along with the commentary on it by Sri Brahmananda Sarasvati, called Laghucandrika and popularly known as Brahmānandī is considered the high-watermark of Advaita dialectics.







सिद्धान्तबिन्दुः

श्रीमन्मधुसूदनसरस्वतीस्वामिनां कृतिः

तस्याः आङ्ग्लभाषानुवादः लघुटिप्पणी च
अचलानन्देन

SIDDHĀNTABINDU

OF

Srimat Madhusūdana Sarasvati

with

English translation and brief notes

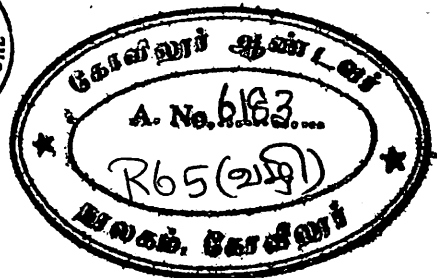
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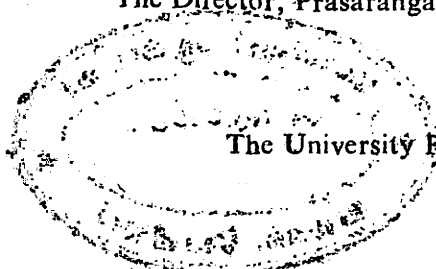
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नमो ब्रह्मादिभ्यो ब्रह्मविद्यासंप्रदायकर्तृभ्यो

वंशकृषिभ्यो

नमो महर्ष्यो नमो गुरुभ्यः

I bow in humble adoration to the line of
seers beginning with Brahma, the Creator,
the makers of the tradition of Wisdom
that is the Infinite.

I bow to the great Ones

I bow to the Preceptors

सिद्धान्त बिन्दुः

श्रीमन्मधुसूदनसरस्वतीस्वामिनां कृतिः

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FOREWORD

The *Siddhānta-bindu* of Madhusūdana Sarasvatī is a valuable introduction to the study of Advaita. It is valuable for two reasons. Being a commentary on Śaṅkara's *Daśaślokī*, it takes the reader to Śaṅkara, the perennial source of inspiration to all those who are interested in Advaita. It also helps the reader to have a taste of the style and argumentative skill of Madhusūdana, one of the masterminds of the school of Advaita.

The *Daśaślokī*, also known as *Cidananda-daśaślokī*, which consists of ten verses, brings out the nature of the Self which is no other than Brahman, distinguishing it from the not-self, which is unreal, insentient, and finite. Śaṅkara says that the Self is one (*eka*), auspicious (*śiva*), free from attributes (*kevala* or *nirdharmaka*) and eternal, *i.e.* what remains for ever without getting sublated (*avaśiṣṭa*). The *Siddhānta-bindu* written by Madhusūdana is a commentary on the *Daśaślokī*. Madhusūdana not only explains the meaning of each verse of the original text, but also elucidates the various aspects of the Advaita school. Though the commentary is called "Siddhānta-bindu", which means, "a drop of the doctrine", it is indeed a summary or digest of several aspects of the Advaita doctrine. Hence its importance and value.

Swāmi Acalānanda's translation of the *Siddhānta-bindu* is lucid and faithful to the original. The notes he has provided will be helpful in understanding the

technical terms and problems. I am sure that this edition of the text with translation will be useful to both scholars and laymen interested in Advaita.

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CONTENTS

Foreword		 iii
Guide to the pronunciation of transliterated		
Sanskrit words		 vi
Abbreviations		 viii
Introduction		 ix
Analysis of the text and translation		 xxiv
<i>Daṣaṣlokī</i>		 xxxi
Text and translation		 1
Glossary		 113
Errata		 133

GUIDE TO THE PRONUNCIATION OF TRANSLITERATED SANSKRIT WORDS

VOWELS

a	short like u in but
ā	long like a in far
i	short like i in pin
ī	long like ee in seen
u	short like u in put
ū	long like oo in root
ṛ	a vowel sound
ḷ	a vowel sound
e	long like ay in bay
ai	long like ai in pain
o	long like oa in boat
au	long like ou in endow
ḥ	the preceding vowel is aspirated, involving an expulsion of the breath

CONSONANTS

When two words are given to illustrate a consonant sound,
the two words are said together and not apart.

k	like c in come
kh	like k h in think hard
g	like g in gum
gh	like gh in ghost
n	preceding k, kh, g, gh like n in pink
c	like ch in church
ch	like ch h in match head
j	like j in judge
jh	like dge h in sledge hammer
n	preceding c, ch, j, jh, like n in pinch
ṭ	like t in top
ṭh	like t h in hot house
ḍ	like d in dance

ḍh	like d h in round house
ṇ	like n in punt
t	like th in pith
th	like th in think
d	like th in that
dh	like dh in <i>Buddha</i>
n	preceding t th, d, dh like n in no
p	like p in put
ph	like p h in up hill
b	like b in but
bh	like b h in climb high
m	like m in mind
y	like y in young
r	like r in run
l	like l in law
v	like v in love
ṣ	like s in <i>Siva</i>
sh	like sh in ship
s	like s in sea
h	like h in hard

ABBREVIATIONS

Ai.U.	..	Aitareya Upanishad
B.P.	..	Brahma Puranam
B.S.	..	Brahma Sutram
B.S.B.	..	Brahma Sutra Bhashyam of Śrī Śankara
B.U.	..	Bṛhadārnyaka Upanishad
B.U.V.	..	Bṛhadarānyaka Upanishad Bhāshya Vārtikam
Bb.U.	..	Brahmabindu Upanishad
Bh.	..	Bhagavatam
Bh.G.	..	Bhagavadgīta
Bh.P.	..	Bhashaparichhedah
Ch.U.	..	Chandogya-Upanishad
I.U.	..	Isavasya Upanishad
Kai.U.	..	Kaivalya Upanishad
K.U.	..	Kathopanishad
Ke.Up.	..	Kena Upanishad
Man.K.	..	Māndūkya Kārika
Nr.U.	..	Nṛsimha-Uttara-Tāpini- Upanishad
Pan.	..	Panchadaśi
S.S.	..	Sankshepa Śārīrakam
Sv.U.	..	Śvetaśvatara Upanishad
T.S.	..	Taittiriya Samhitā
T.U.	..	Taittiriya Upanishad
Y.S.	..	Yāgnavalkya Smṛti

INTRODUCTION

Sri Madhusūdana Sarasvatī is one of the classical writers on the *Advaita Vedānta*. His best known work is the *Advaita-Siddhi*. Together with the commentary on it by Sri Brahmānanda Sarasvatī, called *Laghucandrikā* but better known by its popular name *Brahmānandī*, it is considered the highwater mark of *Advaita* dialectics.

Not much is known about the details of the life of this great saint scholar. But the little that is known is full of interest. Sri P. C. Diwanji of the Bombay Civil Service (judicial) places the date of his birth as 1540 A.D. He tells us also that the name of Madhūsudana Sarasvatī is mentioned in the *Ain-E-Akbari* as the second among the wise men of the Hindus, the first being that of his *guru*, Mādhava Sarasvatī. And Sri Rajendranath Ghosh, in the very elaborate introduction to the Bengali translation of the *Advaita-Siddhi* places the date of his birth between 1525 and 1530. In view of the fact that when he left for Navadvēpa as a very young man determined to enter the monastic order under the guidance of Sri Chaitanya Mahāprabhu (1485-1532) the latter was presumably still alive, it may be necessary to advance the date of birth to 1520. It is agreed by all that he lived for a hundred and seven years.

He was born in a village near Kotalipāra in the Farīdpūr District of East Bengal, now Bangladesh, in a family of erudite scholars, probably followers of the *vaishṇava* faith. The father's name was Pramodana Purandarācārya. The young man, the third of four sons, was named Kamalanayana.

Receiving his early education from his father and making very rapid progress with it, Kamalanayana resolved, even as a very young man, to dedicate his life to the pursuit of truth and to renounce the worldly life, to enable him to concentrate on his aim, without the distraction of having to maintain a family. His father approved his resolve, blessed him and advised him

not to enter the monastic order till he had acquired all the learning required and available.

Resolving and promising his father accordingly, Kamalanayana came to Navadvēpa, hoping to become a disciple of Chaitanya Mahāprabhu. Arriving there he found that the Mahāprabhu had gone away to Puri. Before he could leave for Puri, he probably heard of the passing away of Sri Chaitanya. He then started the advanced study of *Nyāya* under the great scholar Hari Rāma Tarkavāgiṣa. A great devotee of Sri Krishna by temperament and upbringing, he came to believe that the *Advaita Siddhanta* was the greatest obstacle to *bhakti*. So he determined to study it thoroughly so that he could refute it completely and advance the cause of *bhakti*.

For this purpose he went to Vārāṇasī the great seat of *Advaita Vedānta* where his mastery of *Nyāya* was readily recognized and brought him great reputation and honour. He studied the *Advaita-vedānta* under Mādhava Sarasvatī, the foremost of the teachers of *Advaita* at Vārāṇasī.

As the study proceeded, Kamalanayana, who began as a confirmed adversary, studying the system so as to refute it thoroughly, became a convinced convert to the *Advaita* view of Reality, because of his keen intellect and a mind open to conviction. He was then overcome with remorse for the deceit he had practised on the *Guru* to whom he had not revealed his purpose at the beginning. In this repentant mood he confessed his sin to the *guru* and requested him to prescribe a proper atonement for it. The *guru* told him that *sanyāsa* was the atonement for everything and directed him to a brother monk, Visvesvara Sarasvatī for ordination as a monk.

Sri Visvesvara Sarasvatī expressed his joy at getting such a learned candidate for the monastic order but required him, as a matter of form, to write something on the *Advaita-vedānta*, so that his eligibility for ordination could be judged thereby. He began his commentary on the Gita, the *Gūdhārtha-dīpikā*. What was ready of it was shown to Sri Visvesvara Sarasvatī a few months later when he returned from a pilgrimage; it was appro-

ved and Kamalanayana Pandita was ordained as an *Advaitin* monk with the name of Madhusūdana Sarasvati.

Then he commenced the other work set by his master, viz. to repel the latest dialectic attack on *Advaita* by the eminent *Mādhva* saint-scholar Vyasa Tirtha in his '*Nyāyāmṛta*'. This he did in his most famous work the *Advaita-siddhi* wherein, it is said his mastery of the *Advaita Vedānta* and of the *Nyāya* discipline are both seen at their best and subtlest.

It is said that after this work was completed it was seen by Vyāsa Tirtha also, who feeling that it had to be refuted and that he was too old to do it himself directed his disciple Vyāsa Rāmācārya to do it.

The latter came to Kāsi and studied *Advaita-siddhi* under Madhusūdana Sarasvati himself, without revealing his intention. While studying he was also writing his refutation of its thesis and at the end of his study he presented a copy of his writing, the *Nyāyāmṛtataraṅgiṇī* to his teacher. The latter saw it and told Rāmācārya that he had known his intentions, even though they were not revealed by the student and so had taught him the doctrine without reservation. He also told him that it was not proper for him to refute the writing of his own student and that it would be done by a younger man. He asked Sri Brahmananda Sarasvati who was a student of his student Narayana Tirtha to undertake this refutation which he did in the form of the *Laghucandrikā*, a commentary on the *Advaita-siddhi*.

It is said that Madhusūdana Sarasvati had to meet the Emperor Akbar, to ask for his assistance to prevent the killing by Muslim fanatics of Hindu monks, who had taken the vow of non-violence to all forms of life, and so could not defend themselves. As a result of that meeting he organized an order of militant Hindu monks the *nāgās*, for the defence of the other *sanyāsins*. It is also said that he liberalized the admission to monastic order, till then open to the Brahmanas only, to the *dvijās* or *traivarnikās*.

Madhusūdana lived in an age of giants in every walk of life, particularly spiritual life. Saint Tulsidas the poet-saint, author

of the *Rāmacaritamānasa* was a contemporary and a friend. While his reputed meeting with Vallabhacarya, the founder of the *vaishnava* faith prevailing in parts of Western India cannot be easily accepted, there appears to be no difficulty about his meeting with Appayya Dikshita from the South, who spent his last years in Vārāṇāsi and with Visvanātha Trakapanchānana who was a star just rising in the sky of scholarship during the last years of Madhusūdana Sarasvatī.

A large number of works-nearly twenty-are ascribed to the author of the *Siddhanta-bindu*. But some of them are doubtful. These which can be definitely ascribed to him according to Sri P. C. Diwanji are :

1. *Advaita-siddhi*, a work on advaita dialectics, establishing the doctrine after refuting the objections of the eminent *Mādhva* saint and scholar Vyasa Tirtha.
2. *Advaita-ratnarakshā* upholding advaita against the followers of the *Nyāya* school.
3. *Vedānta-kalpalatikā*, a short general exposition of the *advaita*, particularly the *advaitin's* idea of *mukti*.
4. *Siddhanta-bindu*, a commentary on Sri Sankara Bhagavatapada's *Daṣa-śloki*. This is the work now translated.
5. *Sankshepa-sāriraka-sāra-saṅgraha*, a commentary on the *Sankshepa-sāriraka* of Saravajñātman.
6. *Gūḍhartha-dīpikā*, a commentary on the *Bhagavadgīta* based mostly on Sri Sankara's *bhāṣya* and upholding *bhakti* as a valid means to liberation.
7. *Bhagavad-bhakti-rasāyana*, an elaborate exposition of *Bhakti* based mostly on the *Bhāgavata-mahā-purana*, demonstrating that it is also a valid means to *mukti*.
8. *Bhāgavata-prathama-śloka-vyakhyā*, a commentary on the first verse of the *Bhāgavata*.
9. *Mahimnasottra-ṭikā*, expounding the famous hymn of Pushpadanta, as being in praise of Hari as well as of Hara.

10. *Isvaratipatti-prakaśa* an exposition of the various ideas regarding God, held by the different systems of religious thought, prevailing in the country.

Another commentary on the *Gitā*, the *Gitā-nibandha*, which is counted by Sri Rajendranath Ghosh as mentioned in the *Gudhartha-dīpikā* appears to have not been noticed by Sri Diwanji. The *Siddhanta-bindu* has been translated into English by Sri P. C. Diwanji of the Bombay Civil Service (Judicial), published in the Gaekwad's Oriental Series and by Sri Modi, Professor of Sanskrit in the Bhavanagar College. Both these books are not readily available now, this translator got them only after he had completed his work.

There are four commentaries in Sanskrit on the work. (1) The *Bindu-sandipani* of Sri Purushottamananda, (2) The *Bindu-vyakya* of Sri Nārāyaṇa Tīrthā, (3) The *Nyāyaratnāvali* of Sri Brahmānanda Sarasvatī and (4) A modern commentary by Mahāmahopādhyāya Vasudeva Śāstrī Abhyankar of Poona. Only the last two were available to the translator when this translation was being made.

As mentioned earlier, this text is a commentary on Sri Sankara's *Daśa-slokī*, wherein the central theme of the *Advaita Vedānta* is expounded in very simple language. The essential doctrine is the identity of consciousness which is the reality of the individual with the Infinite, the consciousness which is the reality of the universe. From this it follows that it is not right to identify the Self with any of the other categories of experience on which the perceived activity of life is based or which are perceived or conceived or as is done by other thinkers. This is done in the *daśa-slokī* taking up the categories from different points of view. In each of the first eight verses the first two quarters state the denial, the third gives briefly the reason on which the denial is based and the last quarter asserts the accepted identity. In the ninth verse, the first two lines give the reason for the assertion made in the last and the third states the consequent status of the phenomenal world. In the last verse,

however, there is the admission of the futility of trying to express the ineffable.

In the Siddhanta-bindu, the ideas in the original work are elaborated, the refuted views are stated at some length and the schools holding them named. In this process, the basic ideas of *Advaita-vedānta* are clearly enunciated. The explanation of the first verse is by far the longest forming nearly half the text.

Most of the basic ideas of the *advaita* are explained here. The three *vādas* of post-Śaṅkara thought in this school, viz., the *Pratibimba-vāda*, the *Ābhāsa-vāda* and the *Avaccheda-vāda* are explained and reconciled. These will be referred to again a little later.

The commentary on the eighth verse is also very long and there is a detailed discussion here of the states of consciousness. Here also some points of interest are clarified.

To go back to the *vādas*

The *Vādas* are mostly analogies to illustrate a point. They are not reasons which explain why something is happening but analogies to explain how it can be understood. A phenomenon with which we are familiar and which the mind has accepted is chosen and the matter under discussion is shown to be understood like that. To the question why, however, in the ultimate sense, there is no answer. To say that it is because of *Māyā* is an admission that it is unanswerable, because *Māyā* is itself indefinable. *Advaita* admits the position and demonstrates that this is so not because of the system's inability to solve the problem but because the nature of the problem is such. Therefore thinking through analogies is a means of enabling the mind to accept the finding in terms of previously accepted findings.

The problem here is to explain how the One, Being, Brahman appears as many; as the perceived world. The analogy of the rope seen as a snake illustrates how something can appear as something other, as something which it is not, in fact. The discussion of the *Khyāti vādas*, the theories of erroneous perception, leads to the conclusion that while such perception is a fact

(phenomenal), it is not possible to explain why or how it happens. The discussion culminating in this view of the *advaitins* the *anirvacanīya-vāda* is dealt with elaborately in both the *Bhāmātī* and the *Pancapādikā*. But the multiplicity perceived in the 'other' is not sufficiently covered by this illustration, beyond the otherness including multiplicity also.

These three or rather two *vādās*,—because, as we shall see presently, the *pratibimba-vāda* and the *ābhāsavāda* are not substantially different—are analogies to illustrate the multiplicity and the mutability of the perceived and also that these do not affect in any way the oneness and the immutability of the Real.

Again the ultimate Reality is held to be pure absolute existence, Being, Sat, which is identical with pure absolute consciousness, awareness or intelligence, Cit.

In normal life the category with which we are familiar, which comes nearest to pure existence is space. The common, thinking mind accepts this though it is not a datum of sense perception. This is therefore used as an analogy by which the mind can be led to an acceptance of the Infinite. The attributes of space are used to illustrate the integral characteristics (the *svarupa-lakṣhaṇa*) of the Infinite.

The containers like pots, buildings and such others appear to divide space up into separate units with distinct qualities. Space, limited by each container appears to have the shape, size and other qualities of container, and because of these qualities each such delimited space appears to be different from every other, delimited by the apparent division made by the containers. In fact space itself is one, indivisible and totally unaffected by the apparent divisions made by the containers and the apparent distinction among such apparently divided units of space.

Modern scientific thinking makes it possible to take the analogy even further. Science has reduced matter to energy and energy to stress or deformation in space. So even the partitions which apparently divide space, being made of matter are also space only. This makes the apparent nature of the partition clearer.

This is probably the genesis of the *avaccheda-vāda*, the delimitation view. But here the analogy stops and the last step has to be taken by the mind itself because the Infinite is beyond all categorizing, beyond all cognition, while all familiar categories are within the range of cognition. So, for that last step there is no analogy and there can never be any.

Similarly light is the category within phenomenal experience that comes nearest to pure awareness, consciousness or intelligence. While light illumines and makes visible objects which could not be perceived visually without it, it does not need another light to make it visible. Likewise consciousness illumines or enables all things to be perceived, including itself. It does not require a second awareness to know awareness.

Another property of light also illustrates some of the ideas regarding pure consciousness. Light reflected from a reflecting medium does illumine dark places and the objects therein which would otherwise remain unseen. This reflected light can be various and distorted or otherwise deformed by the flaws in the reflecting media. Each such unit of reflected light could be different from the other depending on the variety and differences of the reflecting media. Again, because the reflecting medium has no luminosity of its own, the light which appears to come from it has no reality other than the reality of the original or pure light.

This could be the origin of the *pratibimba-vāda* or the *ābhāsa-vāda* the reflection view or the appearance view which leads the mind towards reality or the infinite as pure consciousness. But this analogy also cannot be taken too far and it cannot lead the mind to pure consciousness itself, which can never be an object of knowing. Like the other analogy of space this also can only prepare the mind for the final leap beyond itself.

Though Sri Madhusūdana Sarasvatī makes the *pratibimba-vāda* and *ābhāsavāda* two distinct views, his senior contemporary in the South, Appayya Dikshita, makes the *ābhāsavāda* a variation of the *pratibimba-vāda*. What happened between the writing of the latter's *Siddhanta-leśasangraha* and the former's

Siddhanta-bindu to account for this difference is a problem to be solved by the historian of Advaita Vedānta.

The difference between the *pratibimba-vāda* which says the reflected image is real and the *ābhāsa-vāda* which says it is unreal appears to be more in the form rather than in the content of the statement. For the *pratibimba-vāda* also holds that the attributes of the reflection such as its location, its lateral inversion facing a direction opposite to the one faced by the object are all false. The only reality that could be predicated of it is what it receives from the object. This does not contradict its being false, because what is perceived as other than the original is nothing but the aggregate of perceived attributes all of which are false.

Śrī Śaṅkara uses the word *ābhāsa*, appearance, to include the *pratibimba*, reflection, also in his *Upadeśasāhasrī* (XVIII, 31-50). Also in the *Brahma-Sūtras* (Ch. II, 3, 50) and Śrī Śaṅkara's commentary thereon, *ābhāsa* includes the *pratibimba*. In fact reflection is also an appearance, a particular form thereof. While the 'reflection' confines the meaning to the specific form reflected, the more comprehensive word 'appearance' includes the diffusion of light through the reflecting medium. But for this the medium itself could be perceived.

There are more than sixty references to *cidābhāsa* in the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka-Upaniṣad-Bhāṣya-Vārtika* of Śrī Sureshvara, who is considered the author of the *ābhāsavāda*. But there is nowhere a suggestion that this is meant to contradict or is offered as an alternative to the *pratibimba-vāda*. It would appear only that Śrī Sureshwara preferred the more comprehensive expression *ābhāsa* and that the authors of the *Pançpādikā* preferred the more specific expression *pratibimba*.

Śrī Madhusudana Sarasvathi has reconciled these *vādas* in the words of Śrī Sureshvaracharya :

*Yatha yatha bhavet pumso vyutpattih pratyagātmani |
sā salva prakriyā jneyā sadhvī sā cānavasthitā ||*

By whichever method a person attains knowledge of the

innerself, that method should be considered the good method and it is not confined to any one method only.

This great principle could be extended beyond the different approaches within a particular school of thinking, to the different schools themselves accepting them all as valuable and valid for their followers. The time that is now wasted by many learned men of all schools in proving other modes of thought to be mistaken could be used beneficially in pursuing the realization of what they hold to be right. The validity of all the views has been reiterated for the modern man by Sri Ramakrishna by arriving at the same goal by all the paths by the effective method of practising them earnestly and with complete faith.

It has been pointed out that the *vādās* discussed here were only analogies to guide the mind from different points of view towards the Infinite. In fact nothing can produce a knowledge of Reality; because Reality, the Infinite, is itself knowledge identical with being. Again the Infinite is one and undifferentiated. The process of knowing which is transitive requires a subject and an object. It is a function of the mind. Since the very characteristic of the mind is to differentiate, no function of the mind can lead to the undifferentiated Being which is also absolute knowledge of awareness. That is way absolute Being which is also pure Consciousness and Bliss is said to be self-evident and not cognizable by any means of knowing, *svatah-siddha* or *svatah-pramāṇa* and *aprameya*.

This self-evident Being-consciousness is eternal, immutable. Therefore it can never become another. But, in our present state, each of us is aware of his identity as an individual, as the fundamental fact to which all other knowing is related. The cause of this, it is held, is ignorance. *Avidyā*, which causes something to appear as something which it is really not; the one to appear as many; pure consciousness as a mixture of knowing and unknowing; the eternal as having a beginning and end and so on *ad infinitum*. This ignorance, *avidyā* or *māyā*, is only a hypothesis which holds only so long as the sense of individuality lasts. The two cease simultaneously.

Now, how is this experienced (within the phenomenal) ignorance to be overcome or destroyed? We know that ignorance can be destroyed only by knowledge and by nothing else. Activity may be necessary to acquire knowledge but it cannot destroy ignorance. Only knowledge can do that. In this case since absolute knowledge is eternal it is not to be brought into being by activity, nor is there any question of acquiring or achieving it, as it is held to be one's own *svarupa*, Being. So all that is to be achieved is the destruction of the hypothetical ignorance.

Again, what is the knowledge that can destroy it? It cannot be pure awareness because that, as pure Being, is the substratum, locus, or basis of everything including even the hypothetical ignorance. Pure awareness is one only, without a second and so there can be no ignorance for it to destroy. Also being without a second it cannot perform the function of destruction because a function, work, invariably presupposes a subject and an object. Therefore the destruction of the hypothetical ignorance can be only within the phenomenon by functioning consciousness.

This functioning consciousness is thought, a function of the mind, a limited form of absolute consciousness delimited or determined by ignorance. And it is with this only that the hypothetical ignorance has to be destroyed.

Here it is necessary to refer briefly to the *advaitin's* idea of the process of perceptual knowing which is the most direct within the phenomenon. We have to remember, again, that according to *advaita*, the cognizing mind, the faculty which is the instrument of cognition and the cognized object are all pure. Being-consciousness only, conditioned by ignorance as apparently distinct entities, which, by their inter-relation, constitute the process of knowing. So in this process, e.g., of visual perception, the mind (*antahkaraṇa*) limited as the instrument of perception goes out through the seat of the visual faculty to make contact with the object to be perceived. Till the moment of such contact the object is not known, so it is said to be

covered by the veil of ignorance. The instrument of perception, therefore, breaks this cover or veil : that is the *āvaraṇa-bhanga*, the breaking of the cover. Then this function of the mind which went out as the instrument of perceptive cognition, takes the form of the object and is reflected in that form ; and that reflection as the cognized function is the result of the cognition, the resulting or reflection, the *phalavṛtti*.

The process of knowing *Brahman* is the same as this. The function of the mind generated by the *mahā-vākya* goes out towards *Brahman* and breaks the veil which now covers it making it unknown. The veil is itself the unknownness of *Brahman* which is the same as our ignorance of it. When this is destroyed the function of the mind takes the form of the object viz., *Brahman*. *Brahman* being infinite has no particular form which would finetize it. So the mind taking the form of *Brahman* means that the mind loses its finiteness. In that moment when finiteness is lost, the mind, or what up to that moment was itself finite and the cause of finiteness and distinction and was called the mind, has lost its characteristic and is not mind. It has become the Infinite or *Brahman*. Then, as there is nothing other there is no reflection in a particular form to a particular cognizer. There is only undifferentiated Being, Consciousness, Bliss, *akhaṇḍam saccidānandam*.

This is the *akhaṇḍākāra-vṛtti*, the mind function as the Infinite. It starts within ignorance, within *Maya*, and ends as the undifferentiated the *akhaṇḍa*. It is like the mental function of working up out of a dream, which starts in the dream state and ends as the waking state. This is also *Jñānam* which, as the *vṛtti*, is the means to emancipation, *Mukti* and as the *akhaṇḍa*, *Mukti* itself.

The functioning mind, however persists as long as the aggregate of the body, faculties and mind continues as such, that is, as long as the individual life lasts. [Since functioning necessarily comes to an end, if that is *mukti* or emancipation, *mukti* would be transient and not eternal. And this would be against the doctrine that *mukti*, is eternal. This doubt does arise

The answer is this :

The *akhaṇḍākāra-vṛtti*, being a *vṛtti*, a function, is certainly transient and does come to an end. But the fact that, even for an instant the mind had lost its finiteness and become identified with the infinite remains as a *samskāra*, an indelible impression in the mind and this sublates all subsequent thoughts even as they rise. This sublation destroys the sense of reality in the content of these subsequent thoughts; they are only *bādhita anuvṛtti*, thoughts the content of which is known to have no reality. Therefore these thoughts are not capable of producing any further impressions on the mind. The old *samskāras* have been destroyed by the *akhaṇḍākāra-vṛtti*; new *samskāras* are not produced because of the memory of that *vṛtti* in the mind, therefore there is no bondage or cause of bondage. That is *mukti*.

What the *akhaṇḍākāra-vṛtti* does is to destroy the illusion that we are bound and not free. Really the Self is *nitya-śuddha-buddha-muktasvabhavaḥ*, ever pure, enlightened and free in its essence.

One more question remains. Why is it that even after long study and an intellectual conviction about Advaita one does not get the experience of the infinite or the *akhaṇḍā-kāra-vṛtti*? What should one do to get it?

The intellectual conviction still remains in the mind only—it is *paroksha*. That is because at the deeper levels there are *samskāras* that cause a hold on the individuality, because of these being *anādi*, having no knowable beginning in time. So to get rid of these one has keep on repeating his conviction mentally till the final function occurs. In practice it means this : As each thought (*vṛtti*) comes to the surface of the mind, one denies reality to its content *athātādeso neti neti* (B.u. ii, 3, 6). This denial is an assertion of his intellectual conviction. This process is the *nididhyāsā* for one following the *vīc.āramārga*, the path of enquiry. This has to be persisted in till the mind attains *jñāna* or the *akhaṇḍākāra-vṛtti*.

These two questions have been dealt with in the introduction to his *vārtikasāra* by Sri Vidyāraṇya.

This work, the Siddhanta-bindu is meant to remove the doubts that linger in the minds of even those who have accepted *advaita*, rather than to convince and convert those holding other views. The translator's hope is that this translation may be of some use to *sādhakās* whose knowledge of Sanskrit is insufficient for them to follow the original. Lacking, as he does, the necessary training in the disciplines of *Nyāya* and *Mīmāṃsā* and also a knowledge of Western philosophical thought he could never dream of producing a work for the approval of scholars, traditional or modern. If in spite of this, scholars find something of value in it, that must be due entirely to the intrinsic value of the original work.

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The translator regrets deeply both the presence and the length of the errata. He would suggest to the reader that the corrections indicated may be carried out before starting the reading of the text. This will make the process of understanding smoother.

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Translator

ANALYSIS OF THE TEXT AND TRANSLATION

	Paragraph
Author's introduction	1
Objection : No need for <i>Ātmajñāna</i>	2
Reply : It is necessary and useful	3
The <i>mahāvākyas</i> , the great statements, the means of knowing <i>Ātman-Brahman</i>	4
Meanings of words and statements	5-7
Objection : Regarding the necessity for discussion	8
Reply : Discussion to dispel doubts caused by the disputants	9
Priority of the <i>tvam-pada-artha</i> , the meaning of the word 'Thou' :	10
View of the <i>Cārvāka</i> , the <i>Vijnānavādin</i> , the <i>Mādhyaṃika</i> , <i>Jaina</i> , <i>Vaiśeṣika</i> , <i>Nyāya</i> , <i>Prābhākara</i> , <i>Bhātta</i> , <i>Sāṃkhya</i> , <i>Yoga</i> and the <i>Upanishads</i> the vedānta	11
Conclusion of the author's introduction as a prelude to verse 1.	12
Verse 1 and its translation	13
Refutation of other views :	15-20
The grounds of refutation	21
The reason elaborated	22-27
Objection : The self absent in ' <i>sushupti</i> ', deep sleep	28
Answer : Awareness present as the witness in deep sleep	29
Proved by the memory of that condition	29
Objection : No need for a witness	30
Answer : Need proved	31
Objection : No evidence for the unchanging witness	32
Reply : Scriptural evidence for the unchanging witness	33
Objections to the rejection of the mind as the knower and answers thereto	34-37

Objection to the reflection of a formless entity and answer to it	38-41
Objection : Regarding absence of evidence for the reflection of the self	42
Answer : Evidence of reflection in the <i>śruti</i>	43
Reflection theory : <i>Pratibimba-vāda</i> and appearance theory : <i>Ābhāsa-vāda</i>	44
Objection to the idea of Super-imposition, <i>adhyāsa</i>	45-48
Answer : General	49
<i>Sruties</i> supporting superimposition, <i>adhyāsa</i>	50
Reasoning supporting <i>adhyāsa</i>	51
Objection to accepting the temporary adjuncts, <i>Upādhis</i> to knowledge	52
Answer by a counter-objection	53
Further answer regarding the necessity for accepting <i>adhyāsa</i>	54-55
Ignorance, <i>avidyā</i> is positive in nature	56
Not a series of mistaken knowings	57
Also the cause of mistake ; and conclusion regarding superimposition and its continuation	58
Progressive extension of superimposition	59-60
Conclusion of the discussion on superimposition	61
The possibility of <i>sūnya-vāda</i> refuted-superimposition is without beginning, <i>anādi</i>	62
Objection to Śankara's description of superimposition	63
Answer and final definition	64
Explanation of all perceived and conventionally accepted distinctions—The Lord and the soul, <i>Iswara</i> and <i>jīva</i> , <i>Vārtika</i> view	65
<i>Iswara</i> and <i>Jīva</i> ; <i>Sankshepa-sariraka</i> view	66
Objection regarding freedom and bondage pertaining to different entities, being <i>vyadhikaraṇa</i>	66
Answer : No inconsistency	67
<i>Ābhāsavāda</i> : The appearance view	68
<i>Vivaraṇākārās</i> view	69
<i>Sankshepa-Sariraka's</i> view	70-71
<i>Avaccheda-vāda</i> , the delimitation view	72

The one-soul view ; <i>ekajīva-vāda</i>	73
Objection regarding contradictory views and answer to them	74-80
Objection regarding distinction of <i>prameya</i> and <i>pramāṇa</i>	81
Answer : The determination of object and means of knowing the two powers of <i>avidyā</i>	82-83
Further elaboration of the distinction	84
The function of the mind in producing cognition	85
Objection that certain categories should be constantly cognized without a function of the mind	86
Answer	87
Objection : How can the Infinite be covered ?	88
Answer : Conceived as covered because of the soul's limitation	89
Objection : The breaking of the veil in ordinary knowing should cause <i>āvaraṇa-bhaṅga</i>	90
Answer : The analogy of fire and the cooling gem	91
Objection : Ignorance irremovable	92
Answer : Ignorance removed and by the knowledge arising from the <i>mahāvākyas</i>	93
Alternative explanation based in a primal ignorance and innumerable secondary ignorances	94
Objection : Is ignorance removed by inference ?	95
Answer : Two kinds of covering, <i>āvaraṇa</i> :	96
Conclusion of this section	97
Objection based on <i>anirvacantya-khyāti</i> , the indeterminate theory of erroneous perception	98
Answer to this	99
Conclusion of verse 1.	100
Perlude to verse 2—Objection If Scripture becomes invalid <i>Brahmajñāna</i> arising from it would also be invalid.	101
Reply to the above and verse 2	102
Some of words explained	103
Introduction to verse 3, and verse 3	104
Explanation of some of the words	105

Condition of deep sleep	106
Objection : It is a void	107
Answer : That is also denied—Positive nature of existence	108-110
Conclusion of the ascertainment of the meaning of 'Thou'—Introducing verse IV	111
The different views regarding the origin of world : <i>Sāṅkhya</i>	112
do <i>Pāsupata</i>	113
Views regarding the origin of the world <i>pāncarātrika</i>	114
do <i>Jains and Tridandins</i>	115
do <i>The mīmāṃsakas</i>	116
do <i>Tārkikas</i>	117
do <i>The Bauddhas</i>	118
do <i>The Pātanjalas</i>	119
do <i>The aupanishadas or vedantins</i>	120
Conclusion of the introduction to verse iv ; and verse iv	121
Meaning of it others Refutation of the views of the <i>sāṅkhyas</i>	122
Refutation of the <i>Saiva</i> , the <i>pāncarātra</i> and the <i>jaina</i> views	123
The <i>Mīmāṃsaka</i> view regarding statements being injunction <i>vidhi</i> refuted	124
Refutation of upanishadic statements being <i>Arthavāda</i>	125
Discussion on ' <i>Vidhi</i> ' concluded	126
Refutation of the <i>Tārkika's</i> view	127
Refutation of the difference-cum-identity view and the view of momentariness	128
Conclusion of Verse-iv	129
Objection regarding the magnitude of <i>Brahman</i> and reply as introduction to verse v ; verse v	130
Explanation of some of the expressions in verse v	131
Objection : The Infinite as the cause of a sorrowful world would become full of sorrow, absence of the highest human purpose. Reply introducing verse vi ; verse vi	132

Explanation of verse vi	133
Objection : To whom is the instruction given ?	134
Reply and introduction to verse vii ; verse vii ;	
Explanation of some of the distinctions between the three states of consciousness—Answer :	
Introduction to verse viii ; verse viii	136
The order of mention of the states	137
Only two categories ; Subject and object consideration of the subject-(1) self	138
Consideration of the subjects (i) God	139
Consideration of the subject as (ii) the soul (<i>Jiva</i>)	140
Consideration of the object	141
Darkeess—positive	142
The uncombined-subtle five elements the <i>antahkaraṇa</i> or mind	143
The faculties produced by the elements	144
The Gods presiding over the faculties	145
The five faculties of knowing	146
The five faculties of activity	147
The body as the locus of the faculties <i>Pañcikaraṇa</i>	148
Discussion on <i>Trivṛtkaraṇa</i> and <i>pañcikaraṇa</i>	149-150
The body-produced by the five elements	151
The process of absorption	152
Total dissolution	153
Distinctions between the three states of consciousness <i>Jāgrat</i> , waking	154
<i>Svapna</i> , dream	155
Objection : Mind becomes the subject, the cognisor ; self-luminosity of the Self lost	156
Answer : Mind cannot be the cogniser	157
The locus of dream-superimposition	158
Objection : The Soul, <i>Jiva</i> , being consciousness cannot be the locus	159
Answer : A particular kind of ignorance admitted	160
Objection : Waking knowing cannot dispel dream ignorance	161
Answer : One kind of ignorance can dispel another	162-164

Alternative : Brahman Consciousness delimited by the mind as locus of dream ignorance	165
Objection : The dream experience of an elephant should be 'I am an elephant'	166
Answer : No, because of the absence of the locus	167
Conclusion of discussion of dream ; <i>taijasa</i>	168
Deep-sleep, <i>sushupti</i> , experiences through the functioning of ignorance, <i>avidyā-vṛtti</i>	169
Distinction from total dissolution, <i>pralaya</i>	170
Ego experienced only in the waking state; transfer of the witness-experience of sleep to the ego of waking	171
Superimposition of Brahman on name etc. an act of the will, reasoning also is such, neither right cognition nor illusion	172
Process of reasoning-four or five types of <i>anvaya-vyatireka</i>	173
Experience of bliss in deep sleep	174
Non-different from God, <i>Iswara</i>	175
States of the mind in waking, cause of distinction among cognisers, the witness limited as cogniser, witness common to all bodies	176
Objection-Memory of painful sleep	177
Answer-painfulness is only the memory of conditions preceding sleep	178
Alternative explanation therefor ; division of each of the three states	179
<i>Adhāytmika</i> , <i>adhidaivika</i> and <i>adhibhautika</i> division of the three states of consciousness	180
Meditation as <i>Hiraṇyagarbha</i> , gradual release ; becoming pure Consciousness immediate release	181
The three states as products of ignorance	182
All distinctions reasonable within the phenomenal, no distinction at all in Reality.	183
Introducing verse ix ; Verse ix	
The witness only immortal ; all else mortal	184-186
Objection : that the self being pure consciousness is not joyful ; answered	187-188

Objection : regarding awareness of joy in <i>mukti</i>	189
Answer : based on the self-evident nature of the Self	190
Objection : even if Bliss is self-evident it is not Self	191
Answer : It is not dependent on anything else ;	
Conclusion	192
Introducing verse x : verse x ; meaning of the 1st quarter	193
All attributes untenable ; the opposite of what is first denied is also denied each time	194-199
Objection : being real and being known at least to be accepted as attributes	200
Denial of these also	201
Demand for indicating the self in a specific manner	202
Impossibility of doing so because it cannot be conveyed as the object of any word	203
How then can <i>vedanta</i> convey knowledge about it ?	204
Only by dispelling ignorance	205
Conclusion of the text	206
Salutations to the ancient <i>gurus</i> , praise of he work, acceptance of the <i>guru's</i> instruction ; composed to help a <i>sādhaka</i> student, judgement left to the generous, wise person ; colophon.	

श्रीमच्छङ्करभगवत्पादस्य कृतिः

दशश्लोकी

न भूमिर्न तोयं न तेजो न वायु-
न खं नेन्द्रियं वा न तेषां समूहः
अनैकान्तिकत्वात् सुषुप्त्येकसिद्धः
तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ १ ॥

न वर्णा न वर्णाश्रमाचारधर्माः
न मे धारणा ध्यानयोगादयोऽपि
अनात्माश्रयाहम्ममाध्यासहानात्
तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ २ ॥

न माता पिता वा न देवा न लोकाः
न वेदा न यज्ञा न तीर्थं ब्रुवन्ति
सुषुप्तौ निरस्तातिशून्यात्मकत्वात्
तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ ३ ॥

न सांख्यं न शैवं न तत्पांचरात्रं
न जैनं न मीमांसकादेर्मतं वा
विशिष्टानुभूत्या विशुद्धात्मकत्वात्
तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ ४ ॥

न चोर्ध्वं न चाधो न चान्तर्न बाह्यं
न मध्यं न तिर्यङ् न पूर्वापरादिक्
वियव्यापकत्वात् खण्डेकरुपः
तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ ५ ॥

न शुक्लं न कृष्णं न रक्तं न पीतं
न कुब्जं न पीनं न ह्रस्वं न दीर्घम्
अरुपं तथा ज्योतिराकारकत्वात्
तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ ६ ॥

न शास्ता न शास्त्रं न शिष्यो न शिक्षा
 न च त्वं न चाहं न चायं प्रपञ्चः
 स्वरूपावबोधो विकल्पासहिष्णुः
 तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ ७ ॥

न जाग्रदमे स्वप्नको वा सुषुप्तिः
 न विश्वो न वा तैजसः प्राज्ञको वा
 अविद्यात्मकत्वात्तयाणां तुरीयः
 तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ ८ ॥

अपि व्यापकत्वाद्वितत्त्वप्रयोगात्
 स्वतस्सिद्धभावादनन्याश्रयत्वात्
 जगत्तुच्छमेतत्समस्तं तदन्यत्
 तदेकोऽवशिष्टः शिवः केवलोऽहम् ॥ ९ ॥

न चैकं तदन्यत् द्वितीयं कुतस्स्यात्
 न वा केवलत्वं न चाकेवलत्वम्
 न शून्यं न चाशून्यमद्वैतकत्वात्
 कथं सर्ववेदान्तसिद्धं ब्रवीमि ॥ १० ॥

सिद्धान्तबिन्दुः

Siddhantabindu

श्रीशङ्कराचार्यनवावतारं विश्वेश्वरं विश्वगुरुं प्रणम्य ।
वेदान्तशास्त्रश्रवणालसानां बोधाय कुर्वे कमपि प्रयत्नम् ॥

Having bowed down in reverence to Viṣveṣvara, the Lord of the Universe, who has descended again as Śri Śankaracārya, I shall make an effort to instruct those who are keenly interested in learning the discipline of *Vedanta*.

१. इह खलु साक्षात्परम्परया वा सर्वान् जीवान् समुद्धिधीर्षुः भगवान् श्रीशङ्करोऽनात्मभ्यो विवेकेन आत्मानं नित्यशुद्धबुद्धमुक्तस्वभावं संक्षेपेण बोधयितुं दशश्लोकीं प्रणिनाय ॥

1. Śri Śankara has composed a short poem called the *Daśaślokī*, ten verses (of instruction) for the purpose of uplifting all souls, directly or gradually, by teaching them briefly about the Self which is pure, enlightened and eternally free as distinct from all non-self.

२. ननु इदद्वारास्पदम्योऽनात्मभ्यो विवेकेनाहद्वारास्पदमात्मानं सर्वो लोकोऽहमस्मीति प्रत्येति दुःखं चानुभवति । तेन ज्ञातज्ञापकत्वान्निष्प्रयोजनत्वाच्च आत्मतत्त्वप्रतिपादनं व्यर्थमिति चेत्—

2. Objection :—But the whole world knows the self, the content of the idea ‘I’, as distinct from the

INVOCATION

The first half of this verse can also mean : “ After bowing down to Viṣveṣvara, the *guru* of the world, who is a fresh incarnation of Sri Śankarācārya, ”

Sri Viṣveṣvara Sarasvatī was the *guru* or spiritual preceptor of Sri Madhusūdana Sarasvatī, the author.

non-self, the content of the idea 'This'; and yet, it continues to suffer. Therefore this instruction about the truth of the Self is futile because it conveys only what is already known and serves no useful purpose.

३. न, चिदभास्यत्वेन लक्षणेन इदङ्कारास्पदानामपि देहेन्द्रियमनसां प्रतिभासतः अहङ्कारास्पदत्वेन तदविवेकात् तेन च शुद्धेऽप्यात्मानि दुःखित्वाद्यभिमानात् शस्त्रीयेण च ब्रह्मात्मैक्यज्ञानेन समूलस्य तस्य निवृत्तेः । तस्मादज्ञातज्ञापकत्वात् सप्रयोजनत्वाच्च आत्मतत्त्वप्रतिपादनं न व्यर्थम् ॥

3. Answer :—It is not so. The body, the faculties and the mind are properly the content of the idea 'This', i.e., they are objects because they are to be illumined by consciousness or awareness. But yet they appear as the content of the idea 'I' as the subject because of non-discrimination. For the same reason, the pure Self is (wrongly) identified with the suffering ego. Knowledge of the identity of the Self (*Ātman*) with the Infinite (*Brahman*), based on the scriptures, completely eliminates all this suffering and its cause. Thus the instruction regarding the truth of the Self is not futile because it teaches something that is not known otherwise and serves a useful purpose.

४. तस्य चात्मतत्त्वस्य 'तत्त्वमसि' 'अहं ब्रह्मास्मि' इत्यादिवेदान्तमहावाक्यमेव प्रमापकम् । वाक्यं च पदार्थज्ञानद्वारेण ज्ञापकमिति तत्त्वपदार्थयोः प्रकृतवाक्यार्थानुकूलयोः अन्यतोऽसिद्धत्वात् तावपि शास्त्रेणैव प्रमातव्यौ यूपाहवनीयादिपदार्थवत् ॥

4. This truth can be known as it is, only through the great statements of the *Upanishads*, "That thou art", "I am the infinite", etc. Statements can convey instruction only through an understanding of the meaning of the words. As the meaning of